

# Colloquialisms and slang

COLLOQUIALISMS AND SLANG ARE FORMS OF INFORMAL SPOKEN LANGUAGE.

Colloquialisms are words or phrases that are used in ordinary, informal speech. Slang is even less formal, and is often only recognized by the members of a particular group. Slang includes words or phrases that may be considered taboo.

## Colloquialisms

English speakers use a variety of informal words and phrases that differ from region to region but are recognized by most native speakers. These words and phrases are called colloquialisms, which stems from the Latin word for “conversation.”

Colloquialisms are an important part of relaxed conversation (known as colloquial speech), but they should not be used in formal speech or writing. Most colloquialisms are labeled in dictionaries as “informal” or with the abbreviation “colloq.”



## Shortened forms

Some words have both a formal meaning and a colloquial meaning. The word *kid*, for example, can refer to a baby goat or, informally, to a child. Colloquialisms are often shorter and easier to say than the word or words they represent. Common colloquialisms therefore include shortened forms of longer words and words that have been combined. They also include abbreviations, such as *ROFL* (“rolling on the floor laughing”), which are used in text messages and e-mail chats in place of longer expressions.

| Shortened form | Formal term       |
|----------------|-------------------|
| 'cos           | because           |
| ain't          | is not            |
| gonna          | going to          |
| wanna          | want to           |
| BRB            | be right back     |
| BTW            | by the way        |
| DND            | do not disturb    |
| LOL            | laugh out loud    |
| TTYL           | talk to you later |

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Some slang terms are used so often that they become **universal**—the slang word *cool*, meaning “fashionable” or “great,” is one example.

### REAL WORLD

#### Rhyming slang

Rhyming slang, also known as Cockney rhyming slang, originated in the East End of London in the nineteenth century. It is formed by replacing a common word with a phrase that rhymes with it. Often, the rhyming part of this phrase is then removed, so the resulting slang term bears little or no resemblance to the original common word. The word *phone*, for example, is translated into rhyming slang as the phrase “dog and bone,” which is then shortened to “dog.”

